

Mercy of the last chance

Mitrabha Guha, the 2026 Commonwealth Chess Championship gold medallist, punched his ticket to Riyadh for the Esports Nations Cup (ENC).

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There is a certain romance about a qualification route that involves a Swiss-system scramble, a double-elimination dogfight and knowing your country has already sent one of its chess stars. Mitrabha Guha, the 72nd Grandmaster of India, would have understood it better than most.

With Nihal Sarin already securing a spot at the Esports Nations Cup, the search for the other player in India's chess roster saw the 24-year-old from West Bengal grind through the regional qualifier like a student writing aggressively in the last minutes of his exam.

The 2026 Commonwealth Chess Championship gold medallist, unsurprisingly, had six wins, three draws, and no losses in the Swiss stage, followed by wins over Malek Koniahli and Artin Ashraf to punch his ticket to Riyadh for the Esports Nations Cup (ENC).

"The regional qualifier was challenging from start to finish. The tournament will bring together some of the strongest players from around the world, so preparation will be key," Guha said.

"Over the coming months, my focus will be on refining different aspects of my game and ensuring I am ready to perform at my highest level when the competition begins."

With India's roster complete in Chess, three more rosters remain in contention for the finals: DOTA 2, MOBA Legends and Rocket League.

The inaugural edition of the ENC will take place in Riyadh, Saudi Arabia, between November 2 and 29. Chess at the tournament will feature 128 players

competing for a prize pool of USD 600,000 (~INR 5.7 crore).

Meanwhile, the marquee event of ENC's organisers, the Esports World Cup, is putting its final touches before the tournament, as the Esports Foundation announced the schedule for EWC Last Chance qualifiers (LCQ).

Set to take place in Paris between July 5 and August 10, the LCQs will award the final qualification spots for 37 solo competitors and six Clubs at the Esports World Cup 2026.

LCQ Schedule and Qualification Slots

- Street Fighter 6 (July 5): 4 players qualify
- Chess (July 9-11): 14 players qualify
- EA FC (July 24-26): 6 players qualify for Play-Ins
- TEKKEN 8 (July 31-August 2): 4 players qualify
- Rocket League (July 31-August 2): 1 Club qualifies
- FATAL FURY: City of the Wolves (August 4-6): 4 players qualify
- Counter-Strike 2 (August 7-9): 4 Clubs qualify
- Call of Duty: Black Ops 7 (August 8-10): 1 Club qualifies

These qualifiers provide a stage for passengers – clubs and players alike — rushing to catch a train that is already leaving the station. And that urgency often promises some of the best contests.

In 2024, EA FC pro João Afonso Vasconcelos aka JAfonso battled through this very round before going on to clinch the title, while India's own subplot saw Sarin seal his spot in the EWC 2025, where he went on to finish as a quarterfinalist.